Donatello's Daily Five

One routine • two homes • Grade 3 in 2026 to Grade 4 in 2027

Start with the same kit

One A5 notebook travels in Don's school bag, with the current reading book, bookmark, pencil, sharpener and this week's eight words. Keep loose sheets together in the same folder; they support the shared notebook rather than starting a second journal.

About 30 minutes after school

1. Read out loud - 10 minutes. An adult listens.
2. Journal - 12 minutes. Thank you for / What happened / The story.
3. Eight words - 5 minutes. Look, say, cover, write, check; three times each.
4. Letters - 3 minutes. One letter family, ten of each, then two words.

Then 10 minutes at bedtime

5. His choice of book. Comics and fact books count. Read himself, share a read-aloud or follow an audiobook. Nobody quizzes him.

Friday changes two blocks

The Friday story replaces the whole daily journal. Dictation replaces word practice. Keep the same order and time limits. Do not add extra work or catch up a missed day.

Who this is for

Donatello (Don), born 8 February 2017. Ricardo and Lauren use the same routine, word set and notebook. A school facilitator, if involved, follows the same handover. Read the adult pages once; keep the cards where the routine happens.

Read aloud, then talk

10 minutes total • calm help • meaning before speed

Help without a struggle

Listen and follow the text. If he is stuck for about three seconds, say the word and let him carry on. Do not turn every hard word into a lesson. Keep the short retell inside the ten minutes.

How much to read

Begin around 300-400 words; build towards 400-600 when comfortable. These are planning amounts, not quotas or school norms. Stop at ten minutes even if the amount is unfinished. Count a typical page once and use page counts as an estimate, not a precise total.

Keep a thread across the week

Revisit the same selected passage on Monday, Wednesday and Friday. On Tuesday and Thursday continue from the bookmark. A short familiar reread can help him notice phrasing and punctuation; it is not a speed race.

A brief conversation

Ask "Tell me what happened in your own words." Then one follow-up: "Why did that happen?" or "How did the character feel?" For a fact book, ask for two things learned and an explanation. A clue in the text can support his answer.

Bedtime stays different

Ten minutes of pleasure, his choice. No word count, no retell, no quiz. Keep the book moving between homes so he can carry on from the same place.

Three headings, one small piece

Monday-Thursday • 12 minutes, including rereading

Thank you for

Build towards two sentences: "I am grateful for ____. It mattered to me because ____." Help him choose a specific moment, person or thing rather than the same general answer each day.

What happened

Build towards three sentences about something real: "First, ____. Then, ____. After that, ____." Say it in order before writing. Occasionally explain how he built something, played a game or solved a problem using the same sequence.

The story

Three sentences: someone in a place; a problem; what happens next. Pick a starter or continue yesterday's story. A story can run for several days. The optional starter questions help if he stalls; they are not extra written answers.

Talk, write, reread

Use roughly two minutes to talk and plan, eight to write, two to reread. Start with one or two sentences per heading if needed; build towards about 60-100 words altogether without extending the block. A small drawing can plan or illustrate an idea, but does not replace the writing.

Four checks, spoken aloud

Does it make sense when I read it back?
Capital at the start and full stop at the end?
Finger spaces between words?
One word I could swap for a better one?

What finished can look like

A model to talk through • not a daily word quota

This is an invented example, not a record of Don's day. It models the three paragraphs; it is not a copying task.

Thank you for

I am grateful that Dad helped me fix my bike. I felt happy because we could ride together again.

What happened

First, we looked for the missing bolt in the garage. Then, I found it under a dusty box. After that, we fixed the wheel and rode to the park.

The story

A tiny dragon was hiding inside my helmet. It sneezed and turned my bike into a rocket. I grabbed the handlebars and flew over the tallest tree in the park.

Friday: one story, not three entries

Choose the best story from the week. Give it a title, a beginning, a middle and an end. Build towards six to eight sentences, in three short paragraphs. Keep all planning and writing inside the same twelve minutes; a clear shorter story is enough today. This is the one planned rewrite, not a demand to redo every page.

Fifteen story starters

Choose a new one, or keep yesterday's adventure going

1. The day the LEGO city came alive.

Who needed your help?

2. A robot that only speaks in football scores.

What was it trying to tell you?

3. The drum that nobody was allowed to hit.

What happened when someone did?

4. I found a door behind the bookshelf.

Where did it lead?

5. The night the moon went out.

Who could switch it on again?

6. My dog learned one word and used it against me.

Which word changed everything?

7. The smallest dinosaur in the world.

Where could you keep it safe?

8. We swapped places for a day.

What was the hardest part?

9. The treehouse had one more room than we built.

What was inside?

10. A goalkeeper who was afraid of the ball.

Who helped the goalkeeper be brave?

11. The puddle that was a portal.

What was on the other side?

12. Everything I touched turned to jelly.

How could you stop it?

13. The last child on Earth, and the Wi-Fi still worked.

Who sent the first message?

14. A snail that wanted to win a race.

What clever plan did it try?

15. The secret the ants were keeping.

Why did they finally tell you?

Eight words, all week

Same scheduled set at both homes • five-minute block

Monday-Thursday

Use all eight words from the week's set. Look at a word, say it, cover it, write it, uncover and check. Repeat three times for each word. Use the practice sheet or the shared notebook. Each attempt is from memory, not copying an uncovered word.

Notice the sounds and letter groups, including any surprising part. The two sight words are a practice category, not a claim that every letter in them is irregular. If an attempt is wrong, notice the part to fix before the next attempt.

Protect the five minutes

The intended routine is three attempts per word, but the five-minute limit still applies. If unfinished, stop and note the next word for tomorrow. Begin there within the same weekly set. Do not add time or a catch-up task. Record unfinished practice so the next adult knows.

Friday: no looking

Cover the list and all practice attempts. The adult says each word, uses it in a sentence, then says it again. Don writes it in the dictation column. Uncover and check together afterwards. Record the words to notice next time without adding a second list or changing the schedule.

Three minutes of letters

Mon: c a d g q
Tue: l h b k
Wed: i j t f
Thu: m n r p
Fri: u v w y
Use school-taught formation. Ten of each letter, then two words using the family, on lined paper in the notebook. Stop at three minutes, even if unfinished.

The word sets · weeks 1-6

Six pattern words + two sight words • keep the same week number

Week 1 · -ck after a short vowel

Pattern: back · kick · sock · duck · pack · rock
Sight: said · was

Week 2 · sh and ch

Pattern: shop · chip · ship · much · wish · chat
Sight: they · there

Week 3 · th and wh

Pattern: this · that · thin · when · which · with
Sight: because · some

Week 4 · ng and nk

Pattern: sing · long · ring · bank · pink · thank
Sight: could · would

Week 5 · Long a / i with final e

Pattern: came · game · time · ride · five · name
Sight: people · friend

Week 6 · Long o / u with final e

Pattern: home · hope · note · bone · tube · use
Sight: again · any

The word sets · weeks 7-12

Six pattern words + two sight words • keep the same week number

Week 7 · ai and ay

Pattern: rain · wait · train · play · day · paint
Sight: many · school

Week 8 · ee and ea

Pattern: see · tree · green · eat · leaf · sleep
Sight: house · water

Week 9 · oa and ow as in snow

Pattern: boat · coat · road · grow · show · float
Sight: want · should

Week 10 · igh and y as in fly

Pattern: high · light · night · right · try · fly
Sight: come · done

Week 11 · ar and or

Pattern: car · star · farm · hard · fork · storm
Sight: our · your

Week 12 · er, ir and ur

Pattern: her · bird · girl · turn · hurt · first
Sight: been · where

The adult's part

The same calm response at Ricardo's and Lauren's

Five useful actions

Let him say the sentence before writing. Supply four or five useful words in a small word bank so spelling does not block the idea. Correct one thing per piece. If he stalls, he talks and you scribe; he reads it back and changes one word. Read the finished piece together and notice a specific success.

One writing focus each day

Monday: capital letters and full stops.
Tuesday: join ideas with because, but or so.
Wednesday: past tense.
Thursday: one describing word or precise detail per paragraph.
Friday: story order and a title.

Bad day: use the short version

Read aloud for ten minutes, write one sentence under each heading, then practise the words once. Do not make up missed work. If his head or eyes hurt, stop the reading; use only comfortable activities. Keep blocks short and use good light. The source note suggests cream paper; use it if comfortable, not as a treatment claim.

Keep pressure out

Do not interrupt a sentence to correct spelling, compare him with another child, repeatedly time him, or redo a page he is proud of. Reading-centre home practice comes first; make room by dropping the story paragraph that day, rather than extending the session.

Sunday: the adult prepares the handover

Ricardo checks the notebook without marking it, selects the scheduled word set, and makes sure the book and sheets travel. Each adult records the next book page and any unfinished word. A few facts on the weekly sheet are enough; no daily report or extra planning for Lauren is needed.

Books, progress & printing

Adult reference • keep the worksheets separate

Books to sample, borrow or choose together

Illustrated: Dog Man, Captain Underpants, Narwhal and Jelly, The Bad Guys. Short chapters: Dragon Masters, Owl Diaries, Press Start!, Usborne Young Reading. Free reading: Book Dash. Audio: Storynory, or a Roald Dahl audiobook with the matching print book. Barrington Stoke / Little Gems is another option to explore. No current stock, price, reading-age match or superiority is claimed. Try a page for comfort and interest; easier books count too.

Progress without a pass mark

The source note reports an earlier check of 90 correct words per minute; the passage, date and test conditions are unspecified. It is a family record, not proof of school readiness. The optional Sunday one-minute check uses an unfamiliar passage: words attempted minus errors and supplied words. Record the date and passage; compare cautiously with his own earlier work. This is weekly adult review, not a sixth daily practice.

The source's EFAL benchmarks and US ORF norms describe different populations and contexts. Ask the teacher to interpret accuracy, understanding and fluency together. No percentile, grade-equivalence or promised weekly gain is assigned here. The earlier 110 goal may be discussed as a family aspiration, not a validated threshold.

Exact print ranges

workbook.pdf: 17 A4 pages. Guide pages 1-11 may be duplex, long-edge. Worksheets 12-17 must be one-sided.
worksheets.pdf: 6 A4 pages, all one-sided. Page 1 journal (four copies for Mon-Thu); page 2 Friday story (one); page 3 words (four copies for Mon-Thu, use Thursday's for Friday dictation); page 4 handover (one weekly); pages 5-6 cards (once).

Print actual size / 100%, A4 portrait; turn off browser headers and footers. Cut cards along their outer border, leaving their printed inner safety margin intact, then laminate. Print page 5 once for one routine card at each home; page 6 holds the notebook check card and travelling word card.

Sources & book resources

Links retained from the supplied files • no new evidence claimed

The two source-note reports are the references for interpreting fluency. No numerical school norm is applied in this pack. The other teaching links came with version 1; resource links help adults find books, not validate benchmarks.

DBE: English Home Language CAPS, Grades 4-6, §3.2.3-4

DBE: English First Additional Language benchmarks (2022)

Reading Rockets: Fluency - An Introduction

Reading Rockets: A New Model for Teaching High-Frequency Words

Source note: DBE / USAID EFAL summary report

Source note: Hasbrouck & Tindal ORF norms, 2017

Book resource: Dog Man / Exclusive Books

Book resource: Book Dash

Book resource: Scholastic Branches

Audio resource: Storynory

Publisher resource: Barrington Stoke

Links are clickable in the PDFs and HTML. Internet access is needed only to visit them; the pack itself opens and prints offline. Availability, prices and external page contents have not been reverified.

My daily journal

Monday-Thursday • date: _____ • day: _____

Thank you for · What mattered, and why?

What happened · First, Then, After that

The story · Three sentences, or carry on yesterday's

My Friday story

Date: _____ • choose a story from this week

Title

Plan · beginning / middle / end (key words or a small sketch)

My story · aim for 6-8 sentences in three short paragraphs

My eight words

Week: _____ • practice date / day: _____ • Friday date: _____

Look · say · cover · write · check. Three attempts. Friday: cover the list and attempts.

No.	Adult's list	Try 1	Try 2	Try 3	Friday
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					

Words to notice / next word if unfinished

Our weekly handover

Week: _____ • starting date: _____ • word set: _____

Current book / passage

Day	Adult / home	Read to page	Next page / word
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			

Next adult: next book page / unfinished word / story to continue

Sunday (optional): date / unfamiliar passage / attempted - errors = correct

One thing that went well / useful note for the next adult

Two home routine cards

Cut on the outer border • one at Ricardo's, one at Lauren's

cut · laminate

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4. Letters · 3 minutes: one family, ten of each, then two words. Stop at three minutes.
5. Bedtime book · 10 minutes, your choice. Nobody quizzes you.

Letters: Mon c a d g q · Tue l h b k · Wed i j t f
Thu m n r p · Fri u v w y
Bad day: read, one sentence per heading, words once. Stop reading if head or eyes hurt.

cut · laminate

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Cards for the travelling notebook

Cut on the outer border • keep both with the shared notebook

cut · laminate

Four checks before I finish

1. Does it make sense when I read it back?

2. Capital at the start, full stop at the end?

3. Finger spaces between words?

4. One word I could swap for a better one?

Read the piece aloud to someone.

cut · laminate

This week's eight words

Week: _____ Starting: _____

1. _____ 5. _____

2. _____ 6. _____

3. _____ 7. _____

4. _____ 8. _____

Friday: cover this card. An adult says each word; I write it without looking.